

Checklist:

Balanced Roadmap

1. Confirm why the roadmap exists

- ☐ Connect near-term product changes to mid-term milestones and the long-term vision.
- ☐ Help marketing, sales, and other teams plan around product direction.
- ☐ Communicate sequencing of priorities.
- ☐ Create alignment around trade-offs.
- ☐ Give product leadership and PMs a shared view of top-level priorities.

2. Classify every roadmap item

- ☐ **Innovation:** Work that moves the product toward the vision.
- ☐ **Iteration:** Improvements to the existing product that add value for customers or businesses.
- ☐ **Operation:** Work required to run, secure, scale, and maintain the product.

3. Make a top-down allocation first

- ☐ Decide the percentage of investment to allocate to innovation, iteration, and operations before ranking individual projects.
- ☐ Make the trade-offs explicit to executives and stakeholders.
- ☐ Use the allocation to prevent loud stakeholders from dominating priorities.
- ☐ Compare items only within the same category, rather than ranking unlike work against each other.
- ☐ Revisit the allocation quarterly or when business context changes.

4. Pick an allocation based on product lifecycle

- ☐ **Pre-alpha / idea:** Mostly innovation.
- ☐ **Post-alpha/launch: Further iteration to address** early feedback.
- ☐ **Beta / approaching product-market fit:** Heavy iteration to find PMF.
- ☐ **Scaling after PMF:** More operation to support growth.

- ☐ **Steady state / maintaining:** Balance operation with the next wave of innovation.

5. Prioritize innovation work

- ☐ Identify the strategic milestone needed to realize the product vision.
- ☐ Prioritize work that directly advances that milestone.
- ☐ Avoid “improvements” that do not meaningfully move the product forward.
- ☐ Involve engineering early to reduce future technical debt.
- ☐ Decide whether the product is still on the growth curve or reaching a plateau.
- ☐ Start planning the next innovation before the current product flattens.

6. Prioritize iteration work

- ☐ Focus on incremental value for customers, the business, or both.
- ☐ Use RICE or a similar scoring model.
- ☐ Score each item for **Reach, Impact, Confidence, and Effort**.
- ☐ Validate confidence using quantitative data, qualitative research, and competitive intelligence.
- ☐ Review the output instead of accepting scores blindly.
- ☐ Check for bias, weak strategic fit, stakeholder impact, and missed themes.

7. Prioritize operation work

- ☐ Reserve a clear portion of roadmap capacity for operational work.
- ☐ Include SLAs, privacy requirements, security needs, COGS, tooling, maintenance, technical debt, and bug fixes.
- ☐ Stack-rank operational work separately from innovation and iteration.
- ☐ Define how bugs will be handled: zero-tolerance, SLA-based, severity-based, or quality-threshold-based.
- ☐ Document the operational prioritization process so stakeholders know what to expect.

8. Manage stakeholder requests

- ☐ Create a clear intake process for one-off requests.
- ☐ Require requesters to understand the cost of using roadmap capacity.
- ☐ Say no to low-value requests that do not justify the investment.
- ☐ Consider a capacity/token system for sales or customer-facing commitments.

- ☐ Protect innovation and operational capacity from being consumed by reactive work.

9. Review before finalizing the roadmap

- ☐ Does the roadmap reflect the product vision?
- ☐ Are innovation, iteration, and operation all represented appropriately?
- ☐ Are trade-offs clear and defensible?
- ☐ Are executives aligned on the allocation?
- ☐ Are stakeholders clear on what will not be done?
- ☐ Is there a documented prioritization method for each category?
- ☐ Is the roadmap balanced for the current stage of the product?